



Building a Web of Trust

The headlines scream, “So many thousands of people deprived of rations, in our national capital, New Delhi.” So how do these people prove they are who they say they are, when Aadhaar verification has failed for some reason or the other? The author takes up the issues concerning trust in a world where machines can be fallible and senior citizens can be easily lured by conmen.

The man smiled and said to me, “Now let us use the left thumb.” I rubbed it against my shirt and tried. The man said, “Let us try the other thumb. You will have to help me. Otherwise ...”

I tried the other thumb. Cleaned it on my shirt and then rubbed it on my forehead to make it moist. The man gave me a big smile and said, “Welcome back and have a pleasant stay.”

This set me thinking, “How do you prove that you are who you say you are.” At US Immigration, my wife and I went to the self-service booths first. There were many automated counters and we could take our time. My wife’s verification was a breeze. A man helped me and my verification was partially successful. But because it was partial, both of us now had to be manually verified. Had my manual verification failed, I expect I would have had to be verified by the security police.

So, while most people may not have a problem with biometric or other verification processes, how do you handle the cases that are problematic? Since crossing international borders is usually a rare occurrence, delayed verification may not be critical. Besides, at borders, governments are willing to spend money on the security process.

The issue of a central authority

I faced difficulties with Aadhaar verification as well. Fingerprint verification just would not work. Fortunately, I could link my registered phone using a one time password (OTP). I wanted to do this just in case the Supreme Court allowed mandatory linking of phones to Aadhaar while I was away. I could not risk the phone used for all the OTPs being disabled.

In another case, the iris verification worked only after a couple of attempts. The person at the counter mentioned that on some days, as many as 40 per cent of the people had problems – not all because of biometrics but also because of a mismatch in the name or age. The operator felt disheartened as he had to deal with the frustrated, retired people who had often come from out of town with their children having taken the day off.

The second issue is related to what happens if you rely on a common authority for authentication. The day I was leaving for the US, I read in a Mumbai paper how a woman had been cheated of ₹ 100,000. It seemed that the recent death of her husband entitled her to an insurance claim of ₹ 10 million. She trusted the phone calls she received because the people who called seemed to know so much. And she believed them when they claimed that they had got all this information from her husband when he took the insurance policy.

True, centralised verification is convenient. But the trouble lies in its convenience. It is far too easy for spammers and con-artists to target their victims. In one case, I myself shared information so easily to a person pretending to be from the income tax office. As it happened, this turned out to be useful. I had informed the caller that my father had passed away a few years earlier. Coincidentally, I stopped getting calls from an investment company wanting to talk to my father!

Retired people are a favourite target of sellers of fake insurance policies. I would actually regard it not as mis-selling but as legalised fraud by the insurance companies. It should be obvious to even an idiot that certain types of policies make no sense for any retired person. One of my relatives got a policy for which he was to pay premium till he was over a 100! He had eight such absurd policies. It was legally too late to force the insurance company to cancel the policies. And my cousin said that his father deserved to lose the money for being so stupid. He refused to approach the consumer courts. Victims of such policies are invariably the ones who are financially vulnerable and are easily misled by false promises of returns.

There is nothing secret or dangerous about announcing your retirement or the death of a loved one except that with a common verification process, criminals can mine data more effectively and target their victims with a greater success rate.

It is important to appreciate that the centralised authentication process does not have to be compromised for the fraudsters to be able to collect the information about their targets. A common thread to link various sources of data is enough.